

SAE 5

English part

Benchmark

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Our client, Les Jardins de Cocagne, is a French network of organic market gardens that employ people excluded from the labour market and sell their vegetables through weekly subscriptions collected at local drop-off points. This benchmark studies five organisations in English-speaking countries that combine organic growing, a social purpose, and a strictly local trade: what they grow in a given area is sold in that same area, to members who collect their vegetables from a nearby drop-off point. For each of them the organisation is presented first, then its website and the online experience offered to its members, since that is the kind of tool our client needs. Each section ends with a table of advantages and disadvantages, and a general table brings them all together at the end.

1. Growing Communities — London, United Kingdom

Growing Communities began in 1993 when thirty households in Hackney agreed to buy their vegetables directly from an organic farm. It now delivers weekly bags of organic fruit and vegetables to around 1,400 households, for an annual turnover of £778,000 in 2019/20, through about fifteen collection points. It grows salad and vegetables on its own sites in Hackney and Dagenham, buys the rest from farms in Kent and East Anglia, and sells exclusively in London. It also runs the first all-organic farmers' market in the city, opened in 2003.

Its website is the most accomplished of the five. The photography is warm and shows real growers, and a visitor understands within ten seconds what the organisation does and how to join. Members manage their subscription entirely by themselves: they can change the size of their bag, pause it during the holidays, swap a vegetable they dislike, and switch collection point without contacting the office.

The weakness is not a design problem but an architectural one. The charity lives at three different web addresses: one presentation site, and two separate shops, one for North and East London and one for South London. A visitor who clicks "Sign in" leaves the site they were reading and lands on another application, with a different look and a separate account. A member moving across the river is registered as a brand-new customer.

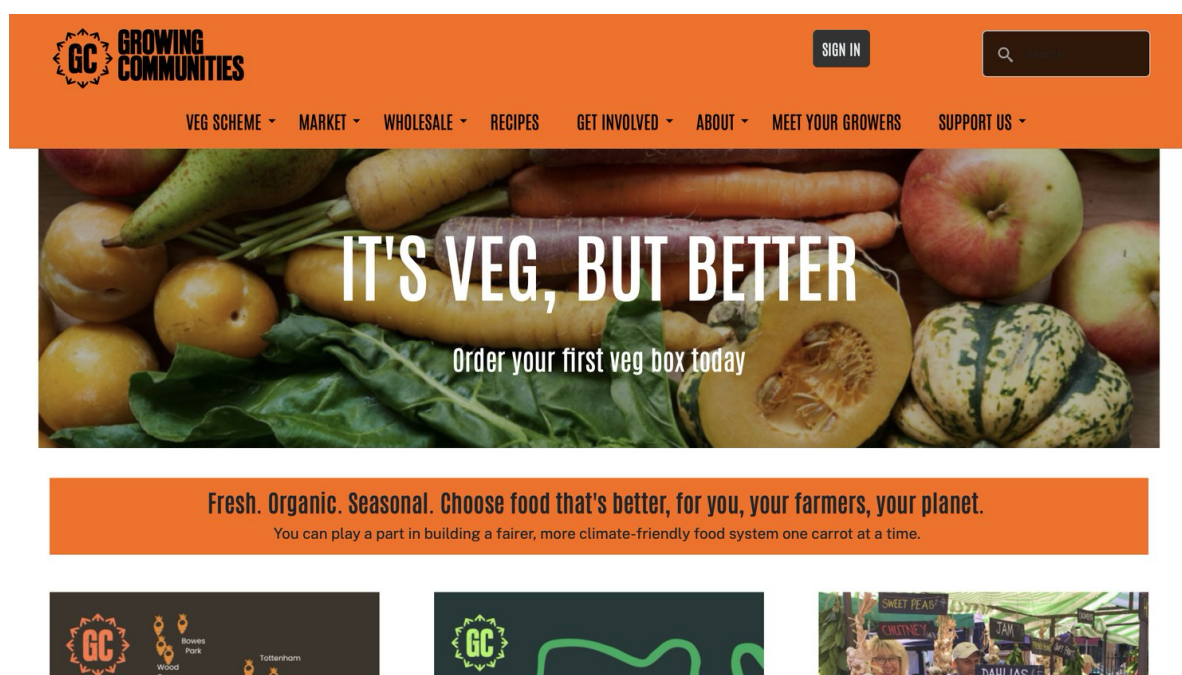


Figure 1 — Home page of growingcommunities.org

Advantages	Disadvantages
Modern design that adapts correctly to mobile screens.	One organisation spread over three separate websites.
Fast pages: compressed images served from a delivery network.	No shared login between the presentation site and the shop.
Complete member area: pause, resize, swap items, change collection point.	Two independent shop instances, so member data is split in two.
Interactive map of collection points, with the nearest one suggested automatically.	Prices only appear once the second website has been reached.
Content kept up to date: weekly recipes and newsletter.	All sales depend on a single external platform the charity does not own.

2. OrganicLea — London, United Kingdom

OrganicLea is a workers' co-operative farming about twelve acres on the edge of London, on land leased from the local council. Everything it grows in Chingford is sold inside the same borough, Waltham Forest, through roughly forty pick-up points. Its pricing is unusual: a bag starts at around £5 a week on a sliding scale, so that members who can afford to pay more openly subsidise those who cannot. The co-operative also runs training placements and a scheme called Cropshare, which buys surplus vegetables from neighbours' allotments and resells them alongside its own.

Its pick-up points are hosted by the subscribers themselves rather than by shops: a member offers a corner of their front garden, receives a lockable box and a padlock, and neighbours collect their bags there. When someone signs up, the site automatically shows the collection points closest to their address.

Online, the co-operative made the opposite choice to Growing Communities: it runs no shop of its own at all. Its ordering system is rented from a specialist supplier and sits on an address belonging to that supplier. The presentation site itself is informative but heavy going, with long blocks of text, few photographs and a design that has clearly not been refreshed for years.

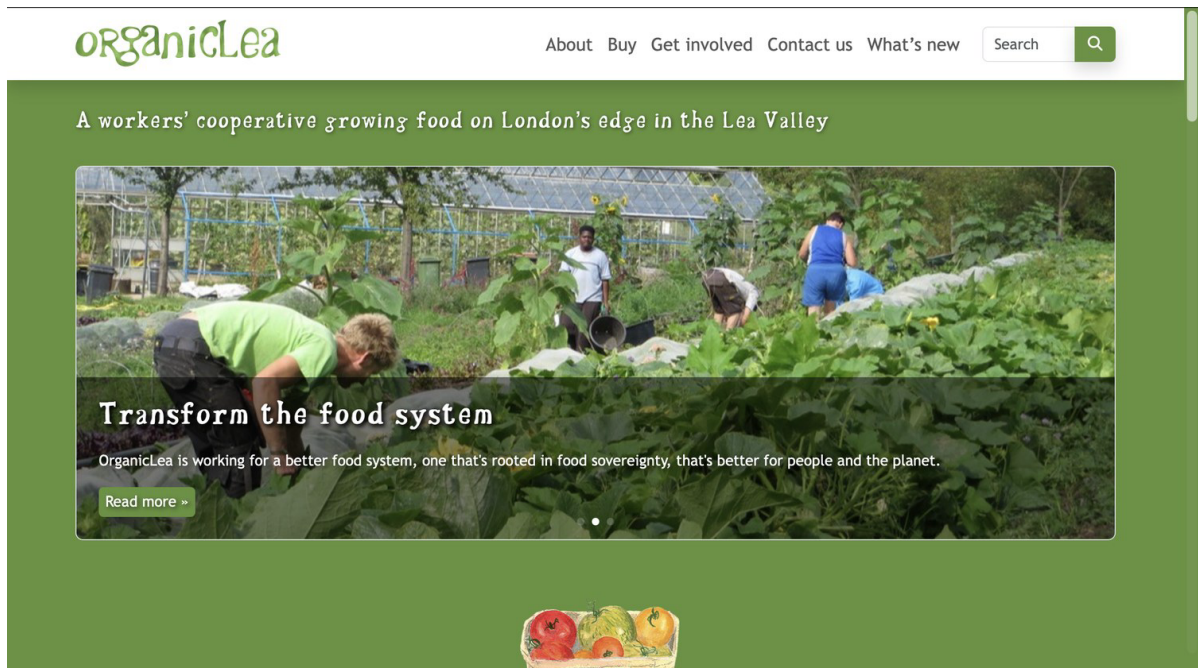


Figure 2 — Home page of organiclea.org.uk

Advantages	Disadvantages
Tiered pricing handled by the ordering system itself, not by hand.	The shop runs on the supplier's address, not on OrganicLea's own domain.
New members are matched automatically to their nearest collection points.	Two disconnected systems: presentation site on one side, shop on the other.
Around forty collection points managed inside the platform.	Dated interface: text-heavy pages, very few images.
No development or maintenance cost: the shop is rented ready-made.	No control over the design, the features, or the data held by the supplier.
	Visitor statistics split across two domains, so traffic cannot be measured properly.

3. Homeless Garden Project — Santa Cruz, California, United States

Founded in 1990, the Homeless Garden Project runs a 3.5-acre certified organic farm in Santa Cruz where people experiencing homelessness are given paid work for a full year, alongside social support and classroom training. The organisation reports that 93% of those who complete the programme go on to find employment. Everything grown in Santa Cruz is sold in Santa Cruz, through a farm stand and a seasonal vegetable subscription, and during the winter the trainees make jams, soaps and candles sold in two local shops.

Its subscription is more sophisticated than a standard vegetable basket. Members choose between a ready-packed share and a “U-Pick” share, where they harvest part of their vegetables themselves on the farm. They can add a handmade product every other week, and the season can be extended into the autumn by buying a separate short subscription.

The problems lie elsewhere. The online shop opens on an address that carries the shop provider’s name rather than the charity’s, at the exact moment a visitor is about to enter card details. Several entries in the main menu look clickable but lead nowhere. And in September 2026 the home page was still advertising the 2024 subscriptions, two seasons out of date.

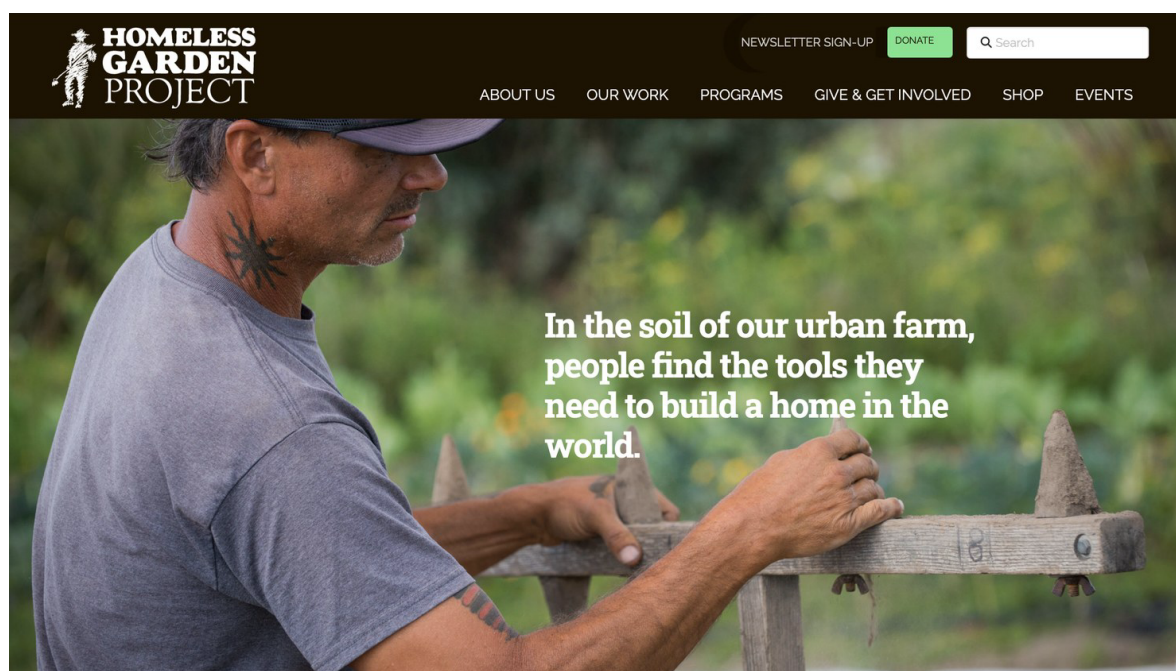


Figure 3 — Home page of homelessgardenproject.org

Advantages	Disadvantages
Clear and consistent navigation across the whole site.	The shop is left on the platform's default address, not the charity's own domain.
Light pages, among the fastest of the five tested.	Several menu entries are dead links with no destination.
Flexible subscription: two share types plus optional extras.	Home page content two seasons out of date.
Photographs and testimonials well integrated into the page templates.	No member account: every change to a subscription goes through email.
	Website, shop and donation form run on three unconnected systems.

4. Growing Home — Chicago, Illinois, United States

Growing Home runs two organic farms in Englewood, a disadvantaged neighbourhood on the South Side of Chicago, and is the only certified organic farm in the city. Its training programme is short and intensive: twelve weeks, paid, aimed at adults facing serious obstacles to employment — a criminal record, homelessness, addiction, long-term unemployment. More than 500 people have been trained since the programme began, and in 2018, 86% of graduates found employment. What is grown in Englewood is sold in Englewood and the surrounding neighbourhoods, with priority given to households that struggle to buy fresh food.

The website is built around the voices of former participants: the home page rotates through short quotations, each linked to a full personal story with a photograph. It is the most emotionally effective of the five, and the least commercial, since the organisation does not sell online at all.

Behind that simplicity lies a real weakness. Every function has been handed to a different outside supplier — job vacancies, donations, the newsletter, application forms and the fundraising campaign each live on a separate service with its own address. Someone who volunteers, donates and applies to the programme exists three times over in three unconnected systems.

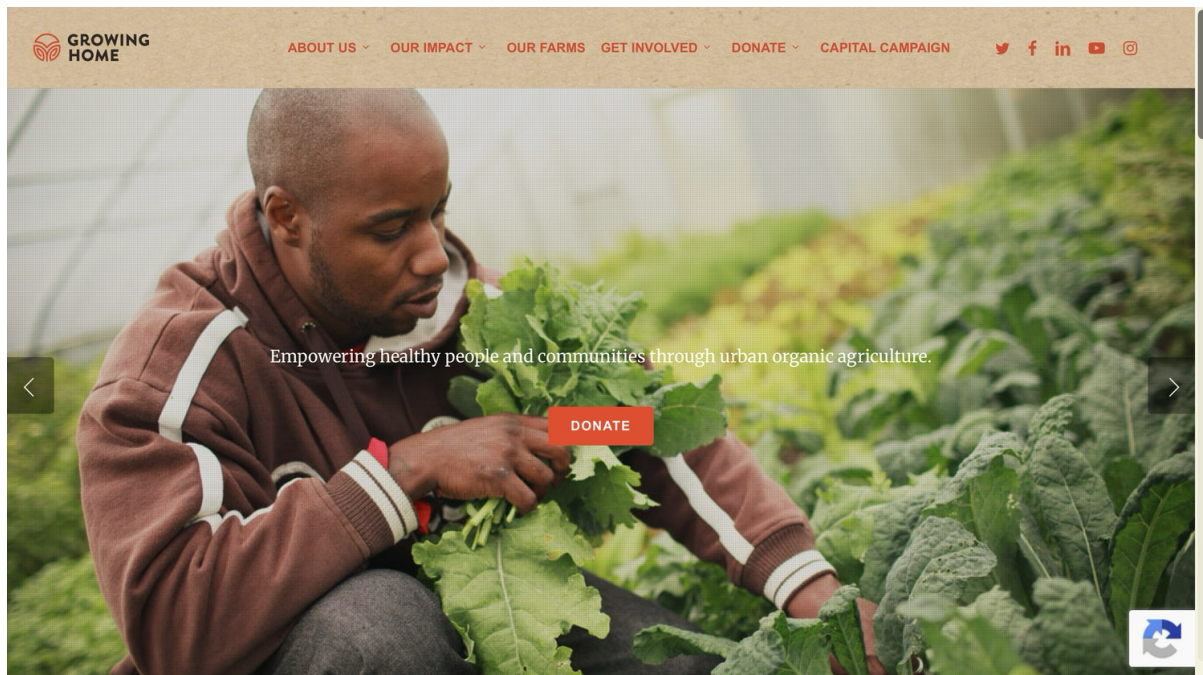


Figure 4 — Home page of growinghomeinc.org

Advantages	Disadvantages
Strong and consistent visual identity across every page.	Zooming is disabled on mobile phones — a genuine accessibility failure.
Effective storytelling: photo galleries and participant profiles.	No online sales: the produce cannot be bought through the site.
The application form for the training programme can be completed online.	Five external services (donations, jobs, forms, newsletter, campaign) with no shared data.
Shallow menu structure: any page is two clicks away.	Heavy pages built with a page-builder tool: the slowest of the five tested.
	Copyright notice five years out of date — a sign of poor maintenance.

5. The Food Project — Greater Boston, Massachusetts, United States

The Food Project, founded in 1991, applies a comparable idea to a different public: instead of adults far from employment, it hires teenagers. Every year around 120 to 140 young people from Boston, Lynn and the surrounding suburbs are paid to farm roughly seventy acres spread over five sites in eastern Massachusetts. They grow more than 110,000 pounds of vegetables, part of which is given to food banks and the rest sold at local farmers' markets, in neighbourhood shops and through a small number of vegetable subscriptions. Nothing travels beyond the region.

One aspect deserves particular attention. A large share of the produce is sold at markets that accept American food-assistance benefits, and the site devotes a whole page to explaining how those benefits can be used to buy fresh vegetables — a solidarity mechanism explained far more clearly than in most French equivalents.

The website is attractive and well structured, and its photographs are compressed automatically so that pages appear quickly. But it is also the least well maintained of the five. The subscription is sold on a completely separate site. Every page silently loads the biographies of the entire staff. And, most seriously, advertising text for an unrelated computer-certification website appears at the bottom of the pages — a clear sign that the site has been compromised, and something that would destroy the confidence of anyone about to donate.

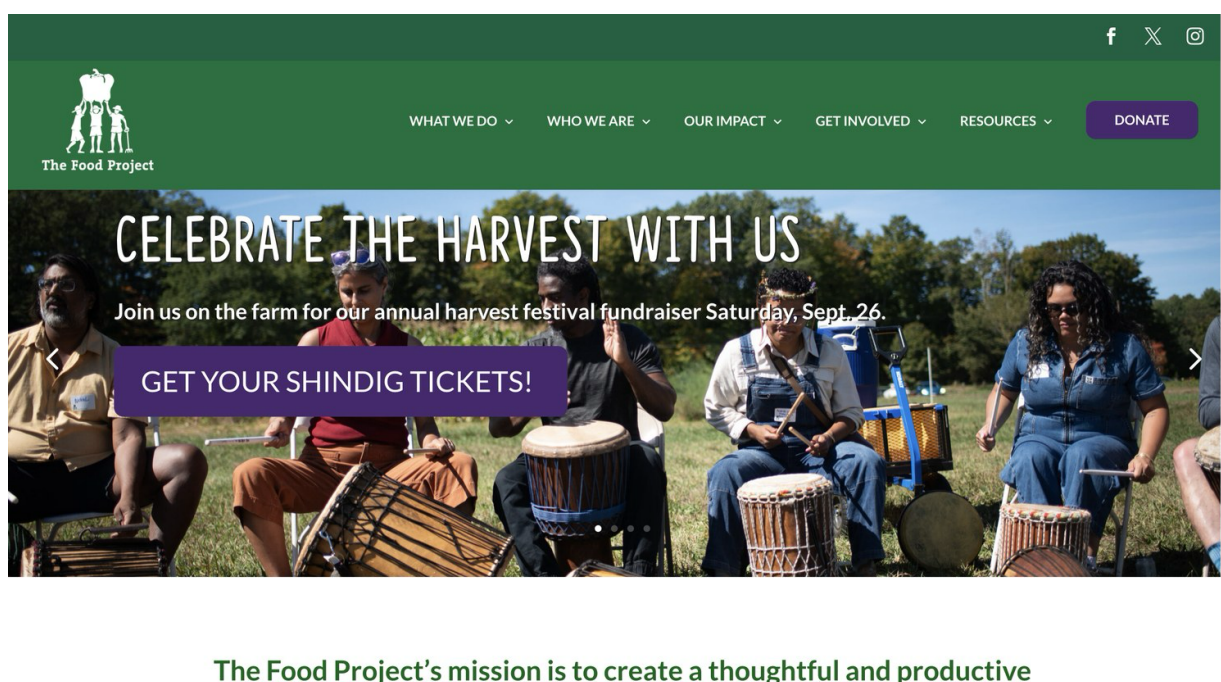


Figure 5 — Home page of thefoodproject.org

Advantages	Disadvantages
Images compressed and converted automatically to a modern format: pages load fast.	Advertising spam injected into the page footer: the site has been compromised.
Clear four-part structure: what we do, who we are, our impact, get involved.	Zooming disabled on mobile phones, exactly as on the Growing Home site.
A dedicated page explains how food-assistance benefits can be used.	The subscription shop is a separate site with a different address and design.
Rich photo and video content on every programme page.	Every page loads the whole staff directory in the background, adding useless weight.
	No online sign-up for the next season: only a newsletter form.

6. General comparison

The table below gathers the advantages and disadvantages identified in each section.

Website	Advantages	Disadvantages
Growing Communities (London)	- Modern, mobile-friendly design. - Fast pages, compressed images. - Complete member area: pause, resize, swap, change depot. - Interactive map of collection points. - Content kept up to date.	- Three separate websites for one organisation. - No shared login between site and shop. - Member data split across two shop instances. - Prices hidden until the second site. - Total dependence on one external platform.
OrganicLea (London)	- Tiered pricing handled by the system, not by hand. - Automatic matching to the nearest collection points. - Around forty collection points managed in the platform. - No development or maintenance cost.	- Shop on the supplier's address, not its own domain. - Two disconnected systems. - Dated, text-heavy interface with few images. - No control over design, features or data. - Visitor statistics split across two domains.

Homeless Garden Project (Santa Cruz)	- Clear and consistent navigation. - Light pages, among the fastest tested. - Flexible subscription with two share types and extras. - Photographs and testimonials well integrated.	- Shop left on the platform's default address. - Several menu entries are dead links. - Home page two seasons out of date. - No member account: changes go through email. - Site, shop and donations on three unconnected systems.
Growing Home (Chicago)	- Strong, consistent visual identity. - Effective storytelling with photo galleries. - Online application form for the programme. - Shallow menu: any page in two clicks.	- Zooming disabled on mobile: accessibility failure. - No online sales at all. - Five external services with no shared data. - Heavy page-builder pages: the slowest tested. - Copyright notice five years out of date.
The Food Project (Greater Boston)	- Images compressed automatically: fast pages. - Clear four-part structure. - Dedicated page on using food-assistance benefits. - Rich photo and video content.	- Advertising spam in the footer: the site has been compromised. - Zooming disabled on mobile. - Subscription sold on a separate site. - Whole staff directory loaded on every page. - No online sign-up for the next season.

7. Conclusion

The five organisations divide neatly into two groups. The two London schemes are far ahead in the way they sell: Growing Communities in particular lets its members pause, resize or move their subscription without ever contacting the office. The three American organisations have the stronger social mission, but none of them offers any real member area, and two of them do not sell online at all.

Three findings stand out. First, a genuine self-service member area is what separates a mature scheme from an amateur one, and it is exactly what a French Jardin de Cocagne cannot offer today. Second, not one of the five keeps the whole relationship in a single system: the website, the shop, the donation form and the newsletter always sit on separate platforms, so the same person exists several times over without the organisation ever noticing. Third, and least expected, these sites suffer less from poor design than from neglect — out-of-date pages, dead menu links, and in one case advertising spam left in place after an intrusion. Building a good tool is not enough; someone has to look after it.

8. Sources

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